



Access Oxbridge Mentor Onboarding Guide

Everything you need to get set up and start supporting your student

Congratulations, and welcome to the Access Oxbridge team! We're really pleased to have you on board and can't wait to see all the great work you do. This short guide walks you through setting up your account on our digital platform, getting you matched up with your student, and running a great first session together. Please read it in full before you begin, and then complete all the steps below. It also sets out what we expect of you as a mentor throughout the programme, and should hopefully clear up any questions you might have.

Your Onboarding Checklist

1. Logged in with the username and password provided
2. Uploaded CV, profile picture and academic credentials
3. Written and added a 100–120 word bio
4. Matched with a student
5. Sent a welcome message via Messages
6. Agreed a time and booked the first session

Getting Started on the Portal

Step 1: Log In

Log in to the portal using the username and password you were provided with. If you haven't received your login details, or you're having trouble accessing your account, contact us and we'll get this sorted for you straight away.

Step 2: Complete Your Profile

Before you can be matched with a student, your profile needs to be complete. Please add the following:

- Your CV
- A profile picture
- Your academic credentials
- A short bio (see guidance below)

Writing your bio (100–120 words)

Your bio is often the first impression your student will have of you, so aim for a tone that is professional yet friendly, warm enough that the student feels reassured and comfortable, while still coming across as credible and experienced.

In around 100–120 words, cover:

- Who you are: a brief introduction to you as a person, not just your job title.
- A warm welcome to the student, so they feel at ease from the outset.
- Your mentoring background and any relevant academic achievements or credentials that build confidence in your ability to support them.

Step 3: Get Matched With a Student

Once your profile is complete, you'll be matched with a student. You don't need to do anything further at this stage; you'll be notified as soon as your match is ready.

Step 4: Send Your Student a Welcome Message

As soon as you're matched, head to the Messages section of the portal and send your student a welcome message. Introduce yourself, and ask when they're free so you can arrange your first session together.

This is also a good opportunity to ask any early questions that will help you prepare, for example, what they'd like to focus on, or where they currently feel they need the most support. The more groundwork you can do over messages beforehand, the more productive your first actual session will be, rather than spending it on introductions and admin.

Sample welcome message

Feel free to adapt this rather than starting from a blank page:



"Hi [Student Name], I'm [Your Name], and I'll be your mentor here at Access Oxbridge, really looking forward to working with you. A little about me: [one line from your bio]. To get our first session booked in, could you let me know a few times that would work well for you over the next day or two? And if there's anything in particular you'd like to focus on early on, feel free to mention it here so I can start thinking it through before we meet. Speak soon!"

Good questions to ask before your first session:

- What would you like to get out of mentoring, and what are your main goals?
- What are you finding most challenging right now?
- Have you already started your personal statement or application materials?
- Are there any deadlines, exams or interviews coming up that I should know about?
- What days or times generally work best for you?

Step 5: Book Your First Session

Once you've agreed a time with your student (ideally within a day or two of being matched), use the Book a Session function to request the session. Once it's confirmed, you're ready to begin.

What We Expect From You as a Mentor

To make sure every student has a consistent, high-quality experience, we ask all mentors to keep the following in mind throughout the programme:

- **Pace the sessions.** Spread your student's total number of hours across the remaining time on their programme, guided by the roadmap and your own judgement of what the student needs.
- **Respond promptly.** Reply to student messages on the portal within 24 hours at the latest.
- **Book the next session before you finish.** In the last two minutes of each session, agree and book the next one in with the student directly; this saves you both having to go back and forth over messages afterwards.
- **Prepare beforehand.** Spend at least 15–30 minutes preparing before each session: refresh yourself on where you left off, mark any work the student has completed, and plan what you'll cover.
- **Set work between sessions.** Give your student tasks to complete outside of your sessions, so they keep making progress and arrive at the next session with something to build on.
- **Maintain professional conduct.** Conduct yourself professionally at all times when interacting with students, on and off the portal.
- **Complete a session report.** Fill out a session report at the end of every session. These are shared with students on request.
- **Protect confidentiality and safeguard your student.** Keep anything your student shares with you confidential, and raise any welfare or safeguarding concerns with the programme team promptly.
- **Keep communication on the portal.** Message your student only through the portal's messaging system, not personal phone numbers, email, or social media.
- **Give notice for changes.** Provide at least 24–48 hours' notice if you need to cancel or reschedule a session, for both your student and the programme team.
- **Keep to standard session length.** Sessions are one hour by default, unless a strategist has specified otherwise.
- **Reach out for support.** Contact Claire on the portal for any guidance, help, or support you need.
- **Give two weeks' notice to step down.** If you need to step down as a mentor, please give at least two weeks' notice.
- **Accept rematch requests.** If a student requests a rematch because they're not satisfied with the service, this will be carried out.

If you have any questions about the portal or your role as a mentor at any point, please get in touch; we're here to support you too.